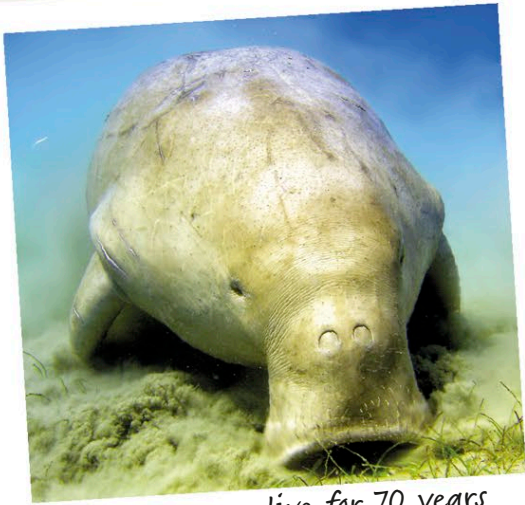


Great Barrier Reef

The world's largest chain of coral reefs, the Great Barrier Reef lies just off Australia's northeastern coast. It's so big that it can be seen from space, and it is home to more than 1,500 types of fish.



Dugongs can live for 70 years or more in the wild.

Dugong

This slow-moving mammal eats nothing but plants. It pulls seagrass out by the roots with its flexible upper lip. Dugongs are also called "sea cows," because they graze like cows.

Coral

Living corals are made up of tiny animals called coral polyps that catch bits of food with their tentacles. The polyps make hard cases from minerals to protect themselves, and these build up over many years into a reef.



Regal tang Also called surgeonfish, tangs have a scalpel-like spine at the base of their tail on both sides.

Giant barrel sponge The barrel sponge is an animal that grows up to 6 ft (1.8 m) across—and it has no brain!

Sea slug Sea slugs eat corals, sea anemones, sponges, and fish eggs. Their bright colors warn predators away.

Blue starfish Tiny suckers, called tube feet, cover the underside of starfish and let them crawl over the reef.

The reef has many different types of coral. In addition to hard corals, which build the reef, there are also soft corals.

Starfish can regrow a damaged or lost arm. Some can even grow a whole new starfish from just part of an arm.